THEORY LAB · 02

# The reviewer said the theory was underdeveloped. You added six citations.

The revision came back with the same comment.

In 1995 two editors explained why.

THE MOVE

# They stopped drawing maps and put up Wrong Way signs.

Sutton was editing ASQ. Staw was editing Research in Organizational Behavior. Both kept rejecting papers for the same reason.

Their diagnosis: the literature on theory building "can leave a reader more rather than less confused." Telling authors to write better theory had not worked.

So they wrote down what keeps arriving instead.

FIVE WRONG WAY SIGNS

# None of these is theory.

1 REFERENCES, naming a theory is not explicating the causal logic it contains

2 DATA, beta weights and informant quotations are the case for a theory, not the theory

3 LISTS OF VARIABLES, “a dictionary of a language that possesses no sentences” (Homans)

4 DIAGRAMS, an arrow shows THAT something moderates, never WHY

5 HYPOTHESES, the bridge between logic and observation, not the logic

THE VOCABULARY

# The distinctions the paper turns on

### Causal logic

The written account of WHY a relationship holds. Sutton and Staw's whole argument is that this, in prose, is the thing none of the five substitutes can supply.

### Throw-away references

Citations to canonical works that show the author belongs to the profession without demonstrating that a theoretical case has been built.

### Data versus inference

An informant's words are data. The claim the researcher draws from them is the theory. The quotation inspired the claim; it is not the claim.

### Scope conditions

Where a proposition is most and least likely to hold. A sign of strong theory, and something a diagram can never show, because an arrow states that something moderates, never why.

# Data and theory, in one example

## THIS IS DATA

From Barker's study of self-managing teams, an informant:

“Now the whole team is around me and the whole team is observing what I'm doing.”

It is vivid. It is evidence. It is not the theory.

## THIS IS THEORY

Because every member holds legitimate authority over every other, and surveillance by many coworkers is harder to evade than surveillance by one boss, self-managing teams constrain members more tightly than hierarchies do.

The quotation inspired the claim. It is not the claim.

A DOCUMENTED CASE

# The most famous diagram in management was not drawn by its author

Maslow never drew a pyramid. His 1943 paper sets out a hierarchy of needs in prose, with far more qualification than the triangle admits.

The shape arrives later, through management textbooks: Keith Davis used a triangular depiction in 1957, Charles McDermid published the pyramid form in 1960, and the textbooks of the 1970s and 1980s fixed it.

**Millions of people can recall the diagram and not one sentence of the argument. That is what Sutton and Staw mean when they say a figure is not a theory.**

Bridgman, Cummings & Ballard (2019), Academy of Management Learning & Education, 18(1), 81–98

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*Both of us can think of instances in which we have used a string of references to hide the fact that we really didn't understand the phenomenon in question.*

Sutton & Staw (1995), on their own published work

## SOURCES

Sutton, R. I., & Staw, B. M. (1995). What theory is not. Administrative Science Quarterly, 40(3), 371–384.

Weick, K. E. (1995). What theory is not, theorizing is. Administrative Science Quarterly, 40(3), 385–390.

DiMaggio, P. J. (1995). Comments on “What theory is not.” Administrative Science Quarterly, 40(3), 391–397.

Bridgman, T., Cummings, S., & Ballard, J. (2019). Who built Maslow's pyramid? Academy of Management Learning & Education, 18(1), 81–98.

ASQ ran the first three together. Weick replies that these “failures” are often traces of theorising in progress. Both replies come later in this series.

THE QUESTION

# Delete every citation, figure and hypothesis from your theory section. Is there an argument left in the prose?

Five minutes with your own manuscript.

Next Saturday: Whetten's four building blocks, and the test that only one of them counts.

Tell me what you found